

EXT. OUTSIDE CORRIDOR - LATE EVENING

VARIAN(20M, SOUTH ASIAN) hurriedly follows ARIS(22M, MIDDLE-EASTERN) out of the conference, before deliberately going in front of him and breaking his path.

VARIAN
You disappeared, and now you want
to act like we're 'cordial'?

Aris tentatively looks around, taking precarious note as passerbys eye them. He stops.

ARIS
I did not realize you still held so
much anger towards me.

VARIAN
Y-you left me!

ARIS
I thought you hated me.

VARIAN
(humiliated)
Hated you? I was there for you at
your lowest. I gave you every
reasonable out. But you refused.
(beat)
Why would I hate you, Aris?

ARIS
Look, I do not wish for there to be
grievances between our courts.

VARIAN
I felt trapped inside a nightmare.
Does it feel good, knowing you have
that kind of influence over people?

ARIS
What in the Hells are you going on
about?

VARIAN
You told everyone you gave up on
me. L-like a miserable coward.

ARIS
Who told you that? That was not-
(beat)
-nevermind. It does not matter.

Varian opens his mouth, slowly digesting the words.

VARIAN

Why did you do this, Aris? *Why?*

Aris is silent. Varian studies him. When Aris looks to the ground, Varian stiffens.

ARIS

My intention was never to hurt you.

VARIAN

But it clearly didn't matter
whether or not you actually did.

Before he can answer, an object skirts to Aris's leg, a passerby running shortly behind.

Varian casts his gaze to the side, clenching the hem of his shirt. The passerby glances nervously between the two as Aris reaches down modestly, and gently hands them the object. They nod their head, taking it in both hands, before scurrying off.

Aris looks to the distance, then back. He exhales and leans forward, hand over his chest, posturing the other in the air.

ARIS

Look, I apologize for whatever it
is I said, or the things I did or
did not do. If you want to yell at
me all evening, by all means do so.
I am rather good at being yelled
at.

Varian's nose flares.

VARIAN

Y-you're serious. Did our entire
connection mean *that* little to you?

Aris is about to answer then stops. He cocks his head to the side with a half-smile.

ARIS

...Are you coming onto me?

VARIAN

Oh my God. Why are you being
like this? Does any of this
even matter to you? *Aris!*

ARIS (CONT'D)

I was merely asking. My dance
card is a bit nonexistent, I
am afraid. But I am
flattered, really.

VARIAN (CONT'D)
You'd rather act like nothing ever
happened than have a real
conversation!?

ARIS
What do you want me to say? I told
you a thousand times over, I do not
have the capacity for this sort of
thing. I *tried*. I really did.

Varian turns as if to leave. Aris audibly sighs.

ARIS (CONT'D)
Will you sit with me?

Varian stiffens, his back still facing Aris.

The latter brushes a hand against the bench. He sits,
crossing one leg over the other. Varian looks over his
shoulder, and Aris inclines his head.

Varian blows air from his nose. He sits on the very edge next
to him, arms bracing on his legs. He leaves a considerable
amount of room between them.

The two stare out into the night.

VARIAN
...Was it all just pretend?

Varian does not even realize the words slip out, caving into
his own arms.

ARIS
Come again?

VARIAN
Everything. I waited so long for
you to write.
(sharp inhale)
Was this all just a farce to you?

Aris raises a brow.

ARIS
I think you are giving me too much
credit. I am not *that* clever.
(beat)
No. No, of course not.

Varian turns away.

VARIAN
Why didn't you write?

Aris looks to his folded hands.

ARIS
I had meant to. But by then, it
already seemed that it was past the
point of no return.

Varian doesn't respond immediately.

VARIAN
We used to be so close. I thought
we were close.

ARIS
We were. We spent a great deal of
time together. Shared so many
memories and adventures. And then...
well, I do not have any regrets.

Varian fixes on the plated token on Aris's vest. Aris
notices, adjusting it into place with a hand.

VARIAN
Did you want to become an Overseer?

Aris pauses, considering.

ARIS
(softly, melancholic)
Yes.

He finally returns Aris's gaze. They stare at each other.

VARIAN
...Is this why you left?

Beat. Aris scoffs.

ARIS
What? No. Heavens, no.

The lines on Varian's face are taut.

ARIS (CONT'D)
I would not lie to you, Varian.

Varian slowly rises.

VARIAN
Like you said to Faeron?

ARIS
So she—
(realizes)
Shit.

Varian lets out a sharp laugh.

VARIAN
As if you would actually write me.

Aris immediately stands.

ARIS
I would not lie to you.

VARIAN
You lied to me—t-to everyone! No
one even asked why I was hurting.
They just cared that you weren't
the one who b-b-broke me.

Aris steps forward, trying to break the distance.

ARIS
I am barely even acquainted with
those lot.

Varian tenses, stepping backwards.

VARIAN
I had no one!

Aris tries to approach him one last time.

ARIS
I never did not want you in my
life.

VARIAN
You wanted me gone! A-a-and I
almost—
(beat)
I-I almost...

Varian stops himself. He turns his face away from view,
struggling to contain his trembling.

Aris contorts his face, almost like shock, pity—or is it
disappointment? His reaching hand drops slack by his side.

VARIAN (CONT'D)
...I couldn't hate you anymore than
you so clearly hate me.

Aris's expression drops. Silence.

ARIS

...It appears whether or not I am
in people's lives, I still hurt
them.

VARIAN

Did you ever even care about me at
all? As a person, as anyone?

Beat.

ARIS

I care.

Varian sits with his words for a moment, his eyes fading into
nothing. For a moment, he might just let himself believe
Aris. He meets his gaze again, eyes tired and cold.

VARIAN

No, you don't.

Aris lingers in front of him, then gradually steps aside.
Only when Varian has walked off does he finally look in his
direction. Alone, Aris sits on the same, rickety bench, where
they used to talk long ago.

CUT TO:

EXT. OUTSIDE CORRIDOR - EARLY EVENING (FLASHBACK START)

A younger Aris sits on the bench, silhouetted by the orange
afterglow, reading. He is beautiful. Varian steps outside,
and goes to sit beside him.

Aris looks up with a soft smile, before returning back to his
novel. Forever in a single moment.

CUT TO:

INT. OUTSIDE CORRIDOR - NIGHT (FLASHBACK END)

CUT TO:

INT. ARIS'S STUDY- LATE NIGHT (FLASHBACK START)

Aris is trying to write a letter addressed to Varian. He
scribbles a few words in cursive, then he scraps it. Then
another. And another.

He stares at a new blank sheet, then sets down the pen.

EXT. OUTSIDE CORRIDOR — LATE EVENING (FLASHBACK END)

Aris is still sitting on the bench, hair disheveled, as the wood groans with coldness. Hyperfixated on the cracks on the ground, he peers out into nothing. He appears almost lifeless, ghastly.

Sensing people start to stir nearby, he breaks from his trance, straightening and sleeking out his suit.

Finally, he gets up and surveys the route he originally intended to take. Instead, he walks the opposite way.